his Indian Classical-meets-electronica style at some major music festivals this year, including the O.Z.O.R.A. Festival in Hungary, and then touring worldwide in 2025, which is when his back catalogue will also be released.

Although he grew up in the UK, the popular percussionist's genre has been electronic as well as Indian classical on the tabla. "I was listening to hip hop and electronic music very, very young in London, and, at the same time, I was into Indian classical music, so there was like a dual cultural identity, which I started combining soon. A lot of it was to do with the metronome. I was told to just practise tabla using this device. But, I thought I may as well use an electro beat, since that was metronomic too. And so, I was practising tabla with electro beats played on the ghetto box on tape or even a record player!" While the melding of music styles came naturally to him, Singh has moved to a purer classical sound as a producer. "I've been recording Indian classical music in a new, immersive way with high resolution. These productions are for audiophiles all over the world, people who love Indian classical music, and invest in Rs 40 lakh sound systems to appreciate the nuances."

The British policy of whitewashing South Asian culture, says **TALVIN SINGH,** is something he would like to see changing

From touring with the band Siouxsie and the Banshees across the USA for the Lollapalooza festival in the 1990s to hundreds of hit remixes, he has done some rather diverse work. Talvin's collaborations with other artistes have been fulfilling, be it Madonna and Björk or Pandit Niladri Kumar and Pandit Rakesh Chaurasia or talented newcomers. "I think collaborations are exciting because you just learn so much from everybody," he says. While he was a leading light among the small group of musicians fuelling the Asian Underground sound in the 1990s and 2000s, resulting in the massive movement that is British Asian music today—his contributions even earning him an OBE—he says that the British policy of whitewashing South Asian culture from their history or music, is something he'd like to see changing.

The last seven years, he has been spending longer in India because he has been dedicating time to learning the surbahar or bass sitar, and also putting together a collection of rare and beautiful instruments, around which he plans to create a museum someday.

On AI and its likely impact on music making, Talvin says, "There's going to be a strong divide between two worlds of music. One is going to be where you don't even need musicians anymore, thanks to AI." The other side of it will be the playing of tabla or instruments with creative/ emotive elements that the human condition brings, which cannot be recreated. "There's a symbiosis of imagination and creation, the subtle things that happen with acoustic performance music, which AI can never get close to. The intimacy of something, which is not perfect, yet beautiful, because it's not perfect...," explains Talvin. ■

–Priya Pathiyan



what made it exciting." The audiences get to hear different dialects of Gujarati–from a Bohri, a Parsi and a Nagar Gujarati woman and from Ahmedabad and Saurashtra. Bhatt, editor of a Gujarati and Hindi web portal, hopes the play broadens the audience base. "The complaint I hear is that the younger generation doesn't come and cannot connect to Gujarati theatre because it feels it is politically incorrect," says Bhatt. "Plays like this will give a ray of hope to the new gen which is interested in doing theatre that's sensitive and thought provoking."

Mody-Kotwal admits that the play's text is now "wired" into her brain. What keeps her connected, and even committed, to it is its impact–how over the years the number of men in the audience has increased; the performances she has done; the discussions and workshops on gender sensitisation post performance; shows done to raise money to help provide legal aid for rape survivors; and the sheer number of women who have come and shared how the accounts resonated with them. And that's why The Vagina Lady won't be stopping anytime soon. ■

–Suhani Singh

The Vagina Monologues will be performed in Gujarati at The Nehru Centre, Mumbai on March 31